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“A *bhi nahin... abhi toh thoda aur
batting karna hai...”*
A strident voice cut through
the hush of a fading afternoon
at the Beckenham County
Ground, where India’s

Under-19 team had just endured a long,
draining session ahead of its Youth Test
against England U-19.

One boy, however, wasn’t ready to leave.
Not yet. He wanted more: more balls, more
time, more of the crease.

The coaches exchanged confused glances
before giving in. Thirty more minutes.

He batted on, unhurried and unwilling to
surrender the moment. It eventually took the
ground staff to step in, a gentle reminder that
the day was done, for him to finally walk off,
bat tucked under his arm, head still
somewhere in the middle.

But the day was far from over.

As he sauntered towards the dressing room,
a small group of girls, dressed in the pink and
blue of the Rajasthan Royals (RR), called out his
name from outside the boundary rope.

He paused. Slightly overwhelmed, but
smiling.

“Samajh nahin aa raha hai bhaiya. Yeh sab

meri photo kyun le rahein hain?”

There was no pretence in that awkward
query. Just the disarming honesty of a
14-year-old.

It’s been a year since then. By now, Vaibhav
Sooryavanshi must know what the fuss is
about.

Having made his First-Class debut for Bihar
at just 12, Sooryavanshi has spent the last few
years dismantling bowling attacks far more
experienced than him. His exploits for his State
and India U-19 earned him an Indian Premier
League (IPL) contract with RR. He wasted little
time in justifying the hype, smashing a
breathtaking 100 off 35 balls in only his second
game.

What followed silenced any lingering doubt.
In the Vijay Hazare Trophy, representing Bihar
against Arunachal Pradesh, he hammered a
stunning 190 off 84 balls, breaking AB de
Villiers’ record for the fastest 150 in List A
cricket.

There’s more.

Earlier this year, he emerged as India’s
leading run-scorer at the U-19 World Cup,
amassing 439 runs at an average of 62.71 and
a staggering strike rate of 169.49, with fifties
against Afghanistan, Zimbabwe and
Bangladesh.

In the ongoing edition of the IPL, he has
raced to 246 runs in his first six matches at
236.54, taking apart some of the best in the
business, including Jasprit Bumrah, with a
defiance that belies his age.

Understandably, the calls for fast-tracking
him into India’s senior side have only grown
louder.

Sooryavanshi turned 15 in March this year,
which means that, according to the
International Cricket Council’s (ICC) Minimum
Age Eligibility criteria, he can represent the
senior national side.

The rule states: “A player will only be eligible
to represent a National Cricket Federation in an
International Match (including ICC Events and
U-19 Events) if he or she is aged 15 or over on
the relevant squad submission date (in the
case of ICC Events including U-19 Events) or on
the date of the first match of the
series/tournament to be played (in the case of
all other International Matches).”

A large section of the cricketing fraternity is
of the opinion that Sooryavanshi should be
picked for India’s T20I tour to Ireland in June.